About Family Tree Maker Abt

The <DATE_RANGE> annotation Date Modifiers in Family Tree Maker provides a compatibility note about date modifiers in Family Tree Maker.

DATE_CALENDAR:= **{Size=4:35}**

[<DATE_GREG> | <DATE_JULN> | <DATE_HEBR> | <DATE_FREN>]
The selection is based on the <DATE_CALENDAR_ESCAPE> that precedes the <DATE_CALENDAR> value immediately to the left. If <DATE_CALENDAR_ESCAPE> doesn't appear at this point, then @#DGREGORIAN@ is assumed.
No future calendar types will use words (e.g., month names) from this list: `FROM`, `TO`, `BEF`, `AFT`, `BET`, `AND`, `ABT`, `EST`, `CAL`, or `INT`.
When only a day and month appears as a DATE value it is considered a date phrase and not a valid date form.

Date Escape	Syntax Selected
`@#DGREGORIAN@`	<DATE_GREG>
`@#DJULIAN@`	<DATE_JULN>
`@#DHEBREW@`	<DATE_HEBR>
`@#DFRENCH R@`	<DATE_FREN>
`@#DUNKNOWN@`	calendar not known

GEDCOM supports a limited number of calendars. For now, the escape sequence `@#DUNKNOWN@` should be used for dates in calendars not supported by GEDCOM.

Swedish Calendar

It is surprising that even GEDCOM version 5.5.1 still doesn't support the Swedish Calendar.
All it takes is adding the escape `@#DSWEDISH@` to the specification.
Conversion between the Swedish, Julian and Gregorian Calendars is trivially easy.

Sweden is the only country to not simply switch from the Julian to the Gregorian Calendar on a single day. Instead of simply skipping 11 calendar days as other countries had done, Sweden decided to gradually switch from the Julian to the Gregorian Calendar by omitting all the leap days in the period 1700 through 1740.
In 1700, Feb 29 was omitted from the Calendar. So, from that day forward, there was as Swedish Calendar that was one day behind the Julian Calendar, and ten days ahead of the Gregorian Calendar. The plan to omit the leap days from 1704 and 1708 wasn't executed: the difference with the Julian Calendar remained one day.
In 1711, Sweden decided to return to the Julian Calendar by adding an extra leap day to 1712, hence the existence of 30 Feb 1712. 30 Feb 1712 in the Swedish Calendar corresponds to 29 Feb 1712 in the Julian Calendar.
From 1 March 1712 forward, Sweden was using the Julian Calendar again, to eventually adopt the Gregorian Calendar in 1753.

Date without Year

The <DATE_CALENDAR> definition states that “When only a day and month appears as a DATE value it is considered a date phrase and not a valid date form.”.

Not allowing dates without a year is an unfortunate decision, and one that remains unmotivated.
The reason *is not* that a value like `23 Aug` is ambiguous, and could be understood to mean either the 23rd of August or August in the year 23; it *cannot* be interpreted as latter, because GEDCOM demands that years are at least 3 digits longs.

It is quite common for people to know birthdays without knowing the birth year, or remember a death date without the death year.
Knowing a date is so valuable in search for documents that could contain the year, that applications should support dates without a year. GEDCOM readers should accept such dates, but issue a warning that the year is missing.

DATE_CALENDAR_ESCAPE:= **{Size=4:15}**

[@#DHEBREW@ | @#DFRENCH R@ | @#DGREGORIAN@ | @#DJULIAN@ | @#DUNKNOWN@]
The date escape determines the date interpretation by signifying which <DATE_CALENDAR> to use. The default calendar is the Gregorian calendar.

Supported Calendars

The selection of supported calendars reveals a Western bias.
There are many calendars the GEDCOM specification does not support, including the Hijiri, Buddhist, Chinese, Japanese and Tibetan calendars.

Space in Calendar Escape

The French Calendar escape, `@#DFRENCH R@`, contains a space. This looks and feels like a mistake, but the GEDCOM grammar allows it, and it *is* what genealogy applications that support the French Revolutionary calendar use and expect.

Known Error

At least one developer assumed the space to be a mistake. Alsyd Parentèle, later MindScape Parentèle, now discontinued, exports `@#DFRENCHR@` (no space) instead of `@#DFRENCH R@`.
The GEDCOM lineage-linked form does not define a date escape `@#DFRENCHR@`.
It is okay for a GEDCOM reader to issue a fatal error and abort upon encountering calendar escape `@#DFRENCHR@`, but it is suggested that GEDCOM readers issue a non-fatal error for each individual occurrence of `@#DFRENCHR@`, interpret it as `@#DFRENCH R@`, and continue processing.

The Gregorian Calendar escape is superfluous

The Gregorian Calendar is the default calendar, so the Gregorian Calendar escape (`@#DGREGORIAN@`) is technically superfluous.

GEDCOM Writer Best Practice

- do not use the Gregorian Calendar escape (`@#DGREGORIAN@`)

GEDCOM Reader Best Practice

- recognise and discard the Gregorian Calendar escape (`@#DGREGORIAN@`)

DATE_EXACT:= **{Size=10:11}**

<DAY> + space + <MONTH> + space + <YEAR>

where:

space = U+0020, the Space character

Date Validation

The FamilySearch GEDCOM specification says nothing about date validation. Genealogy applications should make sure that dates are valid, and that includes knowing the rules for leap years. Getting that right is a significant amount of work, so most developers will want to rely on existing date processing libraries.

References

Behold Blog: Out on Bad Date

DATE_FREN:= **{Size=4:35}**

[
<YEAR>
|
<MONTH_FREN> + space + <YEAR>
|
<DAY> + space + <MONTH_FREN> + space + <YEAR>
]

where:

space = U+0020, the Space character

See <MONTH_FREN>, page 94.

DATE_GREG:= **{Size=4:35}**

[
<YEAR> [+ space + <BEFORE_COMMON_ERA>]
|
<MONTH> + space + <YEAR>
|
<DAY> + space + <MONTH> + space + <YEAR>
|
<DAY> + space + <MONTH>
|
<MONTH> + space + <DUAL_STYLE_YEAR>
|

<DAY> + space + <MONTH> + space + <DUAL_STYLE_YEAR>
]

where:

space = U+0020, the Space character

Dual-style dates are explained in the <DUAL_STYLE_YEAR> definition.

DATE_HEBR:= **{Size=4:35}**

[
<YEAR>
|
<MONTH_HEBR> + space + <YEAR>
|
<DAY> + space + <MONTH_HEBR> + space + <YEAR>
]

where:

space = U+0020, the Space character

See <MONTH_HEBR, page 94.

Calendar Conversion

Genealogy application that show the Gregorian Date for a Hebrew date should take care when converting the date.

In the Hebrew calendar, days start at sunset. When faced with a date without time information, conversion between the Hebrew and Julian or Gregorian calendars should calculate the so-called *tabular date*, which is the corresponding date in the other calendar that has the same daylight period.

Anno Mundi

Previous versions of GEDCOM included an optional “B.C.” after a Hebrew year, which is most definitely a specification error.
That christian phrase is only used with proleptic Julian and Gregorian Calendars, it is never used with the Hebrew calendar.

A Hebrew date may be *preceded* by “AM” (without quotes), which is an abbreviation of *Anno Mundi*, Latin for “Year of the World”. Users who enter Hebrew dates (with or without the `@#HEBREW@` escape) directly into the date field are not unlikely to use this.
There is no proleptic Hebrew Calendar; the Hebrew Calendar is never used for dates before AM 1.

Best Practice

- GEDCOM writers should not write “AM”, as most GEDCOM readers won't recognise this
- GEDCOM readers should accept “AM”, as users may have entered this directly

DATE_JULN:= **{Size=4:35}**

[
<YEAR> [+ space + <BEFORE_COMMON_ERA>]

|
<MONTH> + space + <YEAR>
|
<DAY> + space + <MONTH> + space + <YEAR>
|
<MONTH> + space + <DUAL_STYLE_YEAR>
|
<DAY> + space + <MONTH> + space + <DUAL_STYLE_YEAR>]

where:

space = U+0020, the Space character

Dual-style dates are explained in the <DUAL_STYLE_YEAR> definition.

DATE_PERIOD:= {Size=7:35}

[
FROM + space + <DATE>
|
TO + space + <DATE>
|
FROM + space + <DATE> + space + TO + space + <DATE>
]

where:

FROM = Indicates the beginning of a happening or state.
TO = Indicates the ending of a happening or state.
space = U+0020, the space character

Examples:

FROM 1904 **TO** 1915

= The state of some attribute existed from 1904 to 1915 inclusive.

FROM 1904

= The state of the attribute began in 1904 but the end date is unknown.

TO 1915

= The state ended in 1915 but the begin date is unknown.

DATE_PERIOD TO means THROUGH

Note that DATE_PERIOD's TO is misnamed, and is used to mean THROUGH.

DATE_PHRASE:= {Size=1:35}

<TEXT>

Any statement offered in lieu of a date when the date is not recognisable to a date parser, but which gives information about when an event occurred.

A date phrase must be enclosed in matching parentheses. That demand is not immediately visible in the <DATE_PHRASE> definition, because it is made in the <DATE_VALUE> definition.

Date Phrase

The <DATE_PHRASE> is a bad idea because it enables *anything* in a DATE field. As a matter of principle, text that isn't a date should be in a NOTE record, not inside the DATE field itself.
It is strongly recommended that genealogy software tries to keeps DATE records clean, by working with the user to relegate "date phrases" to a NOTE.

The only text that isn't recognised as a date yet should still be in a date field is a valid date for a calendar that the application does not recognise or GEDCOM does not support. User can actually mark such text as a valid date, for example by including the escape `@FRENCH R@` if the application does not recognise French Revolutionary dates, or the escape `@DUNKNOWN@` for dates in any calendar not supported by GEDCOM.

References

GEDCOM date phrases

DATE_RANGE:= **{Size=8:35}**

[
BEF + space + <DATE>
| AFT + space + <DATE>
| BET + space + <DATE> + space + AND + space + <DATE>
]

where:

AFT = Event happened after the given date.
BEF = Event happened before the given date.
BET = Event happened sometime between date 1 AND date 2
space = U+0020, the Space character

For example, bet 1904 and 1915
indicates that the event state (perhaps a single day) existed somewhere between 1904 and 1915 inclusive.
The date range differs from the date period in that the date range is an estimate that an event happened on a single date somewhere in the date range specified.
The following are equivalent and interchangeable:

Short form	Long Form
1852	BET 1 JAN 1852 AND 31 DEC 1852
1852	BET 1 JAN 1852 AND DEC 1852
1852	BET JAN 1852 AND 31 DEC 1852
1852	BET JAN 1852 AND DEC 1852
JAN 1920	BET 1 JAN 1920 AND 31 JAN 1920

Date Modifiers in Family Tree Maker

The date modifiers `ABT`, `BEF` & `AFT` are three-letter abbreviations. Several old versions of Family Tree Maker use the illegal four-letter abbreviations `ABT.`, `BEF.` & `AFT.` instead; Family Tree Maker adds a fourth character, a full stop, to the abbreviation while it should not.

A GEDCOM 5.5.5 reader *must* support the official date modifiers and *must not*

support any others.
GEDCOM readers for older GEDCOM versions need not accept these illegal date modifiers, but it is trivial to support. Even a GEDCOM reader that supports it should still issue a non-fatal error for each occurrence.

Date Range in FamilySearch PAF

The ability to specify a <DATE_RANGE> is an important feature. Oddly, FamilySearch PAF does not support it, but pops up a message box stating "The date is not standard" when you use it. You can still use date ranges; PAF will (erroneously) treat the <DATE_RANGE> as a <DATE_PHRASE>, and export it exactly the way you entered it (without the enclosing parentheses mandatory for date phrases), so genealogy applications that do support date ranges will import it just fine.
Incidentally, PAF *does* support <DATE_PERIOD>.

DATE_VALUE:= **{Size=1:35}**

[
<DATE>
|
<DATE_PERIOD>
|
<DATE_RANGE>
|
<DATE_APPROXIMATED>
|
(<DATE_PHRASE>)
|
INT + space + <DATE> + space + (<DATE_PHRASE>)
]

The <DATE_VALUE> represents the date of an activity, attribute, or event where:

INT = Interpreted from knowledge about the associated date phrase included in parentheses.
space = U+0020, the Space character

An acceptable alternative to the date phrase choice is to use one of the other choices such as <DATE_APPROXIMATED> choice as the DATE line value and then include the date phrase value as a NOTE value subordinate to the DATE line tag.

The date value can take on the date form of just a date, an approximated date, between a date and another date, and from one date to another date. The preferred form of showing date imprecision, is to show, for example, `MAY 1890` rather than `ABT 12 MAY 1890`. This is because limits have not been assigned to the precision of the prefixes such as `ABT` or `EST`.

Approximate Exact Date

The <DATE_VALUE> definition does allow `ABT` in front of an exact date; the value `ABT 12 May 1890` is legal, but applications should warn the user that `ABT` in front of an exact date specifies an approximate exact date, which seems self-contradictory. Practically all cases of `ABT` in front of an exact date should be either `BEF` (before) or `AFT` (after) in front of that date.

Date Phrases in Parentheses

Note the parentheses around <DATE_PHRASE>; the <DATE_VALUE> definition demands that all date phrases be enclosed in parentheses.

Date Phrases in PAF

FamilySearch PAF 5 includes <DATE_PHRASE> support, but PAF exports date phrases to GEDCOM exactly the way users enter them, *without* the mandatory enclosing parentheses. This is wrong.

FamilySearch GEDCOM 5.5.1 PAF DATE record abusage

FamilySearch's own PAF does not respect the <DATE_VALUE> definition, but abuses date fields in ways not intended or allowed by the FamilySearch GEDCOM specification. PAF includes phrases such as `NOT MARRIED`, `CHILD`, `STILLBORN` and `INFANT` in date fields (without the parentheses mandatory for date phrases).

PAF development was abandoned in 2012. There is no such thing as a PAF GEDCOM 5.5.5 file. A GEDCOM 5.5.5 reader *need not* and *must not* support these PAF forms.

Best Practice

GEDCOM Writer Best Practice

- Always use parentheses around date phrases as demanded by the GEDCOM specification

GEDCOM Reader Best Practice

- Make sure you recognise dates in all the supported calendars
- Treat every date value you do not recognise as a date phrase
- Issue an error for date phrase not enclosed in parentheses

References

Behold blog: Out on a Bad Date

DAY:= **{Size=1:2}**

dd
Day of the month, where dd is a numeric value within the valid range of the days for the associated calendar month.
This value *must not* start with a leading zero.

Date Validation

The description states that the day value must be legal; i.e. the value must be within the valid range of dates for the month.
This demand implies that *genealogy software is expected to validate dates* upon both user input and GEDCOM import.
When validating dates, applications should make sure that the day not only fits the

month, but - for leap days - the year and calendar as well.

30 Feb 1712

The date 30 Feb 1712 was a real date in Sweden. There are records with that date. 30 Feb 1712 on the Swedish Calendar corresponds with 29 Feb 1712 on the Julian Calendar. 30 Feb 1712 isn't a date on either the Julian or Gregorian calendar, but only on the Swedish Calendar, which even GEDCOM version 5.5.1 still fails to support.

DESCRIPTIVE_TITLE:= **{Size=1:248}**

The title of a work, record, item, or object.

DIGIT:= **{Size=1:1}**

A single digit (0-9).

DUAL_STYLE_YEAR:= **{Size=3:7}**

<YEAR> + slash + <DIGIT> + <DIGIT>

where:

slash = U+002F, the Slash character

The three-character part after the year (slash + <DIGIT> + <DIGIT>) is the alternate year indicator.
The alternate year indicator does *not* indicate that the date is uncertain. It creates *dual style date*, which indicates that the year is either the one or the other year, depending on the calendar style. The full year is the Old Style year, the two digits indicate the New Style year.

Dual-Style Dates

The alternate year indicator always has two digits, never one or three, and always indicates the subsequent year. The alternate date indicator must consist of the last two digits of the next year; anything else is a syntax error and *not a date*.

Old Style and New Style

There are two calendar styles, the Old Style (OS) calendar and the New Style (NS) calendar. The Old Style calendar starts the year on the 25th of March while the New Style starts the year on the 1st of January.

Calendar Act

Before 1752, the English used both what was then known as the Historical Year, starting on January 1, and the Civil Year or Legal Year, starting on March 25. That is why Dual-style dates are common in pre-1752 English parish registers.
The Calendar Act of 1750 ended the practice of using both calendar styles by changing the Legal Year to start on January 1, just like the Historical Year.

Many European countries switched from the Julian to the Gregorian Calendar in 1582, England continued to use the Julian Calendar through 1752. The Calendar Act of 1750 enacted two changes; it changed the calendar date on which the Legal Year begins, and it changed the calendar from the Julian Calendar to the Gregorian Calendar. The Legal Year 1751 ran from 25 March 1751 till 1 January 1752. Wednesday 2 September 1752 JC was followed by Thursday 14 Sep 1752 GC.

Dual Style resolves Ambiguity

The simultaneous use of Old Style and New Style before 1752 created ambiguity; the 21st of February might be in the year 1750 according to the Old Style calendar, but in the year 1751 according to the New Style calendar. I could write “21 Feb 1751” hoping that you assume it is New Style, but I might assume wrongly, and if you believe it to be an Old Style date, you might misinterpret it as 21 Feb 1752 New Style. Writing it as“21 Feb 1750/51” disambiguates the date, by providing the years for both styles: it explicitly states that it is 21 Feb 1750 Old Style and 21 Feb 1751 New Style, no confusion possible.

The Old Style year is listed first, the New Style year is listed second. The second year is always the next year, is always indicated by exactly two digits, the last two digits of that year. So “21 Feb 1750/52” is illegal, “21 Feb 1759/60” involves the years 1759 and 1760, while “21 Feb 759/0” is illegal. Even “21 Feb 1759/1760”, arguably an easier to understand more straightforward syntax, is illegal.

Usage

Dual styling may be needed for dates in January, February and most of March (up to, but not including March 25). For the rest March, and all of April through December, the Old Style calendar and the New Style calendar agree on the year, so those dates must not be dual-styled. Using dual-style for a date that isn't ambiguous does not create ambiguity, it creates *not a date*.

Historic Names

Historically, many authors and publications have referred to dual style dates as double dates or dual dating. Those ill-considered names create confusion by suggesting that there are two different dates, while that is not the case at all. There is a single date, in two different calendar styles, hence *dual style date*.

Dual Calendaring

There is also a dual-calendar practice used because of the change from the Julian Calendar (JC) to the Gregorian Calendar (GC, usually indicated with CE). For example, “2/12 May 1608” is 2 May 1608 JC and 12 May 1608 CE.
This dual-calendaring practice is not supported by GEDCOM; GEDCOM demands that you pick a calendar.
Within GEDCOM, the Gregorian Calendar is the default calendar, but several other calendars, including the Julian Calendar, can be specified through the <DATE_CALENDAR_ESCAPE>.

Restrictions

Genealogy applications must ensure correct usage of dual-style dates by enforcing appropriate restrictions.

- Dual style dates may only be used with the Julian and Gregorian Calendar
- The use of two years is indicated by a slash (never a hyphen or any other character)
- The slash must always be followed by two digits, never more or less
- The year indicated by those digits must be the next year
- Dual style may only be used for otherwise ambiguous dates, so only for Jan 1 through March 24
- Dual style may only be used for the year 1923 and earlier

References

GEDCOM Dual-Style Dates

ENTRY_RECORDING_DATE:= {Size=1:90}

<DATE_VALUE>
The date that this event data was entered into the original source document.

EVENT_ATTRIBUTE_TYPE:= {Size=1:15}

[<EVENT_TYPE_INDIVIDUAL> |
<EVENT_TYPE_FAMILY> |
<ATTRIBUTE_TYPE>]

A code that classifies the principal event or happening that caused the source record entry to be created. If the event or attribute doesn't translate to one of these tag codes, then a user supplied value is expected and will be generally classified in the category of other.

EVENT_DESCRIPTOR:= {Size=1:90}

Text describing a particular event pertaining to the individual or family. This event value is usually assigned to the EVEN tag. The classification as to the difference between this specific event and other occurrences of the EVEN (event) tag is indicated by the use of a subordinate TYPE tag selected from the <EVENT_DETAIL> structure. For example:

1 EVEN Appointed Zoning Committee Chairperson
2 TYPE Civic Appointments
2 DATE FROM JAN 1952 TO JAN 1956
2 PLAC Cove, Cache, Utah, United States of America
2 AGNC Cove City Redevelopment

EVENT_OR_FACT_CLASSIFICATION:= {Size=1:90}

A descriptive word or phrase used to further classify the parent event or attribute tag. This should be used whenever either of the generic **EVEN** or **FACT** tags are used. The value of this primitive is responsible for classifying the generic event or fact being cited. For example, if the attribute being defined was one of the persons skills, such as woodworking, the **FACT** tag would have the value of `Woodworking', followed by a subordinate TYPE tag with the value `Skills'.

1 FACT Woodworking
2 TYPE Skills

This groups the fact into a generic skills attribute, and in particular this entry records the fact that this individual possessed the skill of woodworking. Using the subordinate TYPE tag classification method with any of the other defined event tags provides a further classification of the parent tag but does not change the basic meaning of the parent tag. For example, a **MARR** tag could be subordinated with a **TYPE** tag with an <EVENT_OR_FACT_CLASSIFICATION> value of `Common Law.'

1 MARR
2 TYPE Common Law

This classifies the entry as a common law marriage but the event is still a marriage event. Other descriptor values might include, for example,`stillborn' as a qualifier to BIRT (birth) or `Tribal Custom' as a qualifier to MARR (relationship).

The <EVENT_OR_FACT_CLASSIFICATION> is an open-ended feature.
There is no list of pre-defined, accepted or suggested descriptor values.

TYPE tag Correction

The FamilySearch GEDCOM 5.5.1 description for <EVENT_OR_FACT_CLASSIFICATION> references <EVENT_DESCRIPTOR> instead of <EVENT_OR_FACT_CLASSIFICATION> as intended.

This is an editing error, made upon the introduction of FACT and FACT.TYPE in GEDCOM 5.5.1. This specification error has been highlighted in the *Annotated Edition* and corrected in GEDCOM 5.5.5.

This error was first noted by Keith Riggle and mentioned in several software reviews. It was documented by Tim Forsythe in his 22 Dec 2015 GigaTrees blog post *A New GEDCOM 5.5.1 Wrinkle*, but that blog post is no longer available. It is now documented in Keith Riggle's own blog post *The Event Structure in GEDCOM Files*.

References

GenealogyTools: The Event Structure in GEDCOM Files

EVENT_TYPE_CITED_FROM:= **{Size=1:15}**

[<EVENT_ATTRIBUTE_TYPE>]

A code that indicates the type of event which was responsible for the source entry being recorded. For example, if the entry was created to record a birth of a child, then the type would be BIRT regardless of the assertions made from that record, such as the mother's name or mother's birth date. This will allow a prioritised best view choice and a determination of the certainty associated with the source used in asserting the cited fact.

EVENT_TYPE_FAMILY:= **{Size=3:4}**

[ANUL | CENS | DIV | DIVF | ENGA | MARR |
MARB | MARC | MARL | MARS | EVEN]

A code used to indicate the type of family event. The definition is the same as the corresponding event tag defined in Appendix A. (See Appendix A, page 121).

EVENT_TYPE_INDIVIDUAL:= **{Size=3:4}**

[ADOP | BIRT | BAPM | BARM | BASM |
BURI | CENS | CHR | CHRA |
CONF | CREM | DEAT | EMIG | FCOM |
GRAD | IMMI | NATU |
RETI | PROB | WILL | EVEN]

A code used to indicate the type of individual event. The definition is the same as the corresponding event tag defined in Appendix A. (See Appendix A, page 121).

EVENTS_RECORDED:= **{Size=1:90}**

[<EVENT_ATTRIBUTE_TYPE> |
<EVENTS_RECORDED>, <EVENT_ATTRIBUTE_TYPE>]

An enumeration of the different kinds of events that were recorded in a particular source. Each enumeration is separated by a comma. Such as a parish register of births, deaths, and marriages would be BIRT, DEAT, MARR.

FILE_CREATION_DATE:= **{Size=10:11}**

<DATE_EXACT>
The date that this GEDCOM file was created.

GEDCOM_CONTENT_DESCRIPTION:= **{Size=1:248}**

A note that a user enters to describe the contents of the lineage-linked file in terms of "ancestors or descendants of" so that the person receiving the data knows what genealogical information the file contains.
This value occurs in the GEDCOM header; usage of CONC or CONT records is not allowed.

GEDCOM_FILE_NAME:= **{Size=5:248}**

The name of the GEDCOM file. A GEDCOM file name should use the format *basename.ext*, and use the file extension `.GED` (or `.ged`). GEDCOM 5.5.5 increases the maximum file name length from 90 to 248 code units.

The <GEDCOM_FILE_NAME> is specified as the HEAD.FILE line value. The HEAD.FILE line value should match the name of the GEDCOM file itself, but when a GEDCOM file is renamed by a user, the HEAD.FILE line value does not change with the file name.

<GEDCOM_FILE_NAME> should be just the regular file name (base name plus extension), *without* a file path. The file name should *not* be enclosed in parentheses.

Whether file names are case-sensitive is platform-dependant. All GEDCOM reader and writer file handling code should be case-preserving.

GEDCOM Writer Checklist

- The line value must be the name of the GEDCOM file itself.
- Use only the regular filename (basename plus extension)
- *Do not* include a file path
- *Do* include the file extension.
- Use the file extension `.GED` or `.ged`
- *Do not* use parentheses around the name.
- File handling code must be case-preserving.

ID_NUMBER:= **{Size=1:30}**

A third-party number assigned to an individual.
This IDNO line value must be used for all third party numbers. The IDNO record has a TYPE subrecord to identify what kind of number is being stored.

For example:

1 IDNO 43-456-1899
2 TYPE Canadian Health Registration

The IDNO record is not restricted to national numbers. The IDNO record should be used for all third-party numbers, and the REFN record for all user-defined numbers.

LANGUAGE_ID:= **{Size=1:15}**

A list of valid language identification codes.

The following Latin language codes may be used by all systems (including code page-based systems):

[Afrikaans | Albanian | Anglo-Saxon | Catalan | Catalan_Spn | Czech | Danish | Dutch |

English | Esperanto | Estonian | Faroese | Finnish | French | German | Hawaiian | Hungarian | Icelandic | Indonesian | Italian | Latvian | Lithuanian | Navaho | Norwegian | Polish | Portuguese | Romanian | Serbo_Croa | Slovak | Slovene | Spanish | Swedish | Turkish | Wendic]

Additional languages supported by Unicode-based systems:

[Amharic | Arabic | Armenian | Assamese | Belorusian | Bengali | Braj | Bulgarian | Burmese | Cantonese | Church-Slavic | Dogri | Georgian | Greek | Gujarati | Hebrew | Hindi | Japanese | Kannada | Khmer | Konkani | Korean | Lahnda | Lao | Macedonian | Maithili | Malayalam | Mandarin | Manipuri | Marathi | Mewari | Nepali | Oriya | Pahari | Pali | Panjabi | Persian | Prakrit | Pusto | Rajasthani | Russian | Sanskrit | Serb | Tagalog | Tamil | Telugu | Thai | Tibetan | Ukrainian | Urdu | Vietnamese | Yiddish]

LANGUAGE_OF_TEXT:= {Size=1:15}

[<LANGUAGE_ID>]
The human language in which the data in the GEDCOM file is normally read or written. It is used primarily by programs to select language-specific sorting sequences and phonetic name matching algorithms.

MONTH:= {Size=3}

[JAN | FEB | MAR | APR | MAY | JUN | JUL | AUG | SEP | OCT | NOV | DEC]

where:

JAN = January
FEB = February
MAR = March
APR = April
MAY = May
JUN = June
JUL = July
AUG = August
SEP = September
OCT = October
NOV = November
DEC = December

MONTH_FREN:= {Size=4}

[VEND | BRUM | FRIM | NIVO | PLUV | VENT | GERM | FLOR | PRAI | MESS | THER | FRUC | COMP]

where:

VEND = VENDEMIAIRE
BRUM = BRUMAIRE
FRIM = FRIMAIRE
NIVO = NIVOSE
PLUV = PLUVIOSE
VENT = VENTOSE
GERM = GERMINAL
FLOR = FLOREAL
PRAI = PRAIRIAL
MESS = MESSIDOR
THER = THERMIDOR
FRUC = FRUCTIDOR
COMP = JOUR_COMPLEMENTAIRS

MONTH_HEBR:= {Size=3}

[TSH | CSH | KSL | TVT | SHV | ADR | ADS | NSN | IYR | SVN | TMZ | AAV | ELL]

where:

TSH	= Tishri
CSH	= Cheshvan
KSL	= Kislev
TVT	= Tevet
SHV	= Shevat
ADR	= Adar
ADS	= Adar Sheni
NSN	= Nisan
IYR	= Iyar
SVN	= Sivan
TMZ	= Tammuz
AAV	= Av
ELL	= Elul

MULTIMEDIA_FILE_REFERENCE:= {Size=1:259}

A complete local or remote file reference to the auxiliary data to be linked to the GEDCOM context. Remote reference would include a network address where the multimedia data may be obtained.

The <MULTIMEDIA_FILE_REFERENCE> definition is for multimedia files only.
The GEDCOM specification has a separate <GEDCOM_FILE_NAME> definition for the HEAD.FILE line value.

Whether file names are case-sensitive is platform-dependant. Make sure your file handling code is case-preserving.

The maximum path length specified by GEDCOM 5.5.1 was only 30 code units, which isn't a realistic maximum length for a full path.
The *Annotated Edition* corrected the maximum to be 259 code units. GEDCOM 5.5.5 makes that the official maximum length.

MULTIMEDIA_FORMAT:= {Size=3:4}

[AAC | AVI | BMP | ePub | FLAC | GIF | JPEG | JPG | MKV | mobi | MP3 | PCX | PDF | PNG | TIFF | TIF | WAV]

where:

AAC	= Advanced Audio Codec
AVI	= Audio Video Interleaved (Windows)
BMP	= BitMaP (Windows)
ePUB	= Electronic Publication (ebook)
FLAC	= Free Lossless Audio Codec
GIF	= Graphics Interchange Format (CompuServe)
JPEG, JPG	= Joint Photographic Experts Group
MKV	= Matroska Video Container
mobi	= MobiPocket (ebook)
MP3	= MPEG-2 Audio Layer III
PCX	= Personal Computer eXchange (PaintBrush)
PDF	= Portable Document Format
PNG	= Portable Network Graphics
TIFF, TIF	= Tagged Image File Format
WAV	= WAVeform audio file format (Windows)

Indicates the format of the multimedia data associated with the specific GEDCOM context. This allows processors to determine whether they can process the data object. Any linked files should contain the data required, in the indicated format, to process the file data. GEDCOM readers must accept any casing for the enumerated formats, but GEDCOM writers should use the casing preferred in text written for humans.

GEDCOM 5.5.5 expands the list of allowed multimedia formats. The fact that the enumeration of allowed formats is supposed to be exhaustive remains a fundamental issue.

Four-Letter `JPEG` & `TIFF` versus Three-Letter `JPG` & `TIF`

The GEDCOM 5.5 specification includes the four-letter values `JPEG` and `TIFF`, while the GEDCOM 5.5.1 specification includes the three-letter values `JPG` and `TIF`, probably because some editor thought they should allow three-letters values only. That edit should not have been made, because now the two three-letter values are invalid in GEDCOM 5.5 while the four-letter values are invalid in GEDCOM 5.5.1.
Of course, in practice, most GEDCOM 5.5.1 reader accept the four-letter value without so much as a warning, but many GEDCOM 5.5 readers do not accept the three-letter values.

GEDCOM 5.5.5 uses the four-letter abbreviations, not only because those are the original abbreviations, but also because these are ones already supported by *both* GEDCOM 5.5 and GEDCOM 5.5.1 readers.
A GEDCOM 5.5.5 writer must use `JPEG` & `TIFF` exclusively. Systems must continue to support `JPG` & `TIF` when reading GEDCOM 5.5.1 files.

NAME_OF_BUSINESS:= {Size=1:90}

Name of the business, corporation, or person that produced or commissioned the product.

NAME_OF_PRODUCT:= {Size=1:90}

The name of the software product that produced this GEDCOM file.

NAME_OF_REPOSITORY:= {Size=1:90}

The official name of the archive in which the stated source material is stored.

NAME_OF_SOURCE_DATA:= {Size=1:90}

The name of the electronic data source that was used to obtain the data in this GEDCOM file. For example, the data may have been obtained from a CD-ROM disc that was named "U.S. 1880 CENSUS CD-ROM vol. 13".

NAME_PERSONAL:= {Size=1:120}

```
[
<NAME_TEXT>
|
/<NAME_TEXT>/
|
<NAME_TEXT> + space + /<NAME_TEXT>/
|
/<NAME_TEXT>/ + space + <NAME_TEXT>
|
<NAME_TEXT> + space + /<NAME_TEXT>/ + space + <NAME_TEXT>
]
```

where:

space = U+0020, the Space character

The surname of an individual, if known, is enclosed between two slash (/) characters. The order of the name parts should be the order that the person would, by custom of their culture, have used when giving it to a recorder. Early versions of Personal Ancestral File ® and other products did not use the trailing slash when the surname was the last element of the name. If part of a name is illegible, that part is indicated by an ellipsis (...). Capitalize the name of a person or place in the conventional manner — capitalize the first letter of each part and lowercase the other letters, unless conventional usage is otherwise. For example: McMurray.

Examples

William Lee /Parry/	given name William Lee, surname Parry
William Lee	given name only or surname not known
/Parry/	surname only
William Lee /Mac Parry/	both Mac and Parry are part of the surname Mac Parry
William /Parry/ Boatsman	surname Parry embedded in the name string
William Lee /Pa.../	surname partly unknown (unreadable)

Name Guidelines

The FamilySearch GEDCOM specification for <NAME_PERSONAL> includes a few quick guidelines on how to record names. The key guideline provided here is to capitalise names in the conventional manner (so *not* in ALL-CAPS).
The article *Genealogy Name Basics* provides more *do's and don'ts*.

References

- Genealogy Name Basics
- Five Freaky Features Your Genealogy Software should *not* have

NAME_PHONETIC:= **{Size=1:120}**

The phonetic variation of the name is written in the same form as the name used in the superior <NAME_PERSONAL> primitive, but phonetically written using the method indicated by the subordinate <PHONETISATION_METHOD> value, For example if hiragana was used to provide a phonetic transcription of a name written in kanji. then the <PHONETISATION_METHOD> value would indicate ‘kana’. See <PHONETISATION_METHOD>, page 100 .

NAME_PIECE:= **{Size=1:90}**

The piece of the name pertaining to the name part of interest. The surname part, the given name part, the name prefix part, or the name suffix part.

NAME_PIECE_GIVEN:= **{Size=1:120}**

[<NAME_PIECE> | <NAME_PIECE_GIVEN>, <NAME_PIECE>] Given name or earned name. Different given names are separated by a comma.

NAME_PIECE_NICKNAME:= **{Size=1:30}**

[<NAME_PIECE> | <NAME_PIECE_NICKNAME>, <NAME_PIECE>] A descriptive or familiar name used in connection with one's proper name.

NAME_PIECE_PREFIX:= **{Size=1:30}**

[<NAME_PIECE> | <NAME_PIECE_PREFIX>, <NAME_PIECE>]
Non indexing name piece that appears preceding the given name and surname parts.
Different name prefix parts are separated by a comma.
For example:
Lt. Cmndr. Joseph /Allen/ jr.
In this example **Lt. Cmndr.** is considered as the name prefix portion.

Nobility Titles

The <NAME_PIECE_PREFIX> should not be used for recording nobility titles. Nobility titles must be recorded as the <NOBILITY_TYPE_TITLE> line value of an INDI.TITL record.

NAME_PIECE_SUFFIX:= {Size=1:30}

[<NAME_PIECE> | <NAME_PIECE_SUFFIX>, <NAME_PIECE>]
Non-indexing name piece that appears after the given name and surname parts. Different name suffix parts are separated by a comma.
For example:
Lt. Cmndr. Joseph /Allen/ **jr.**
In this example **jr.** is considered as the name suffix portion.

NAME_PIECE_SURNAME:= {Size=1:120}

[<NAME_PIECE> | <NAME_PIECE_SURNAME>, <NAME_PIECE>] Surname or family name. Different surnames are separated by a comma.

NAME_PIECE_SURNAME_PREFIX:= {Size=1:30}

[<NAME_PIECE>]

Surname prefix or article used in a family name.

A surname prefix that consists of multiple parts is written *as is*, and not modified in any way. Thus, the surname prefix for the surname “de la Cruz” is “de la”.

FamilySearch's instruction, present in GEDCOM 5.5 and 5.5.1, to comma-separate parts of the surname prefix, and write “de, la” instead of “de la” *must be ignored*, even in GEDCOM 5.5 and 5.5.1 files.
That erroneous instruction remains unmotivated, and no genealogy application is known to follow it. Modifying a surname prefix by inserting one or more commas is sure to create those superfluous commas in your reports.

NAME_ROMANISED:= {Size=1:120}

The romanised name is written in the same form prescribed for the name used in the superior <NAME_PERSONAL> context. The method used to romanise the name is indicated by the line value of the subordinate <ROMANISATION_METHOD>. For example if romaji was used to provide a transliteration of a name written in kanji, then the <ROMANISATION_METHOD> subordinate to the ROMN tag would indicate `romaji`.
See <ROMANISATION_METHOD>, page 105.

NAME_TEXT:= {Size=1:120}

<TEXT> excluding commas, numbers, special characters not considered diacritics.

NAME_TYPE:= {Size=5:30}

[aka | birth | immigrant | maiden | married | <user defined>]

Indicates the name type, for example the name issued or assumed as an immigrant.

aka	= also known as, alias, etc.
birth	= name given on birth certificate.
immigrant	= name assumed at the time of immigration.
maiden	= maiden name, name before first marriage.
married	= name was person's previous married name.

user defined = other text name that defines the name type.

NATIONAL_OR_TRIBAL_ORIGIN:= {Size=1:120}

The person's division of national origin or other folk, house, kindred, lineage, or tribal interest. Examples: Irish, Swede, Egyptian Coptic, Sioux Dakota Rosebud, Apache Chiricawa, Navajo Bitter Water, Eastern Cherokee Taliwa Wolf, and so forth.

NOBILITY_TYPE_TITLE:= {Size=1:120}

The title given to or used by a person, especially of royalty or other noble class within a locality.

NULL:= {Size=0:0}

A convention that does *not* indicate the line value `NULL`, nor the Null character (U+0000), but the complete absence of a line value.

NUMBER:= {Size=3:4}

[<DIGIT> | <NUMBER>+<DIGIT>]

> **<NUMBER> Size**
>
> <NUMBER> definition only occurs in the definition of <YEAR_GREG>. As a year is at least three digits long (see <YEAR_GREG> definition), at most 4 digits long; GEDCOM will surely have been replaced before 10.000 CE.

NUMBER_OF_RELATIONSHIPS:= {Size=1:3}

The number of different relationships (family groups) that this person was known to have been a member of as a partner, regardless of whether the associated relationships are present in the GEDCOM file.

OCCUPATION:= {Size=1:90}

The kind of activity that an individual does for a job, profession, or principal activity.

PEDIGREE_LINKAGE_TYPE:= {Size=5:7}

[adopted | birth | foster]

where:

adopted = indicates adoptive parents.
birth = indicates official parents (birth parents).
foster = indicates child was included in a foster or guardian family.

A code used to indicate the child to family relationship for pedigree navigation purposes. When <PEDIGREE_LINKAGE_TYPE> is absent, official parentage (`birth`) is assumed.

GEDCOM 5.5.5 is essentially GEDCOM 5.5.1 from 1999. GEDCOM 5.5.1 predates both affordable consumer DNA testing and the Genealogy Framework. That explains why GEDCOM 5.5.5 supports official genealogy (birth parents are the parents on the birth certificate), but does not support biological genealogy (parents confirmed by DNA tests) yet.

PHONE_NUMBER:= {Size=1:25}

A phone number.

PHONETISATION_METHOD:= **{Size=5:30}**

[<user defined> | hangul | kana]

The phonetisation method used for creating the phonetic text.

<user defined> = record method used to arrive at the phonetic variation of the name.
Hangul = Phonetic method for transcribing Korean glyphs.
kana = Hiragana and/or Katakana characters were used in transcribing the kanji character used by Japanese

PHYSICAL_DESCRIPTION:= **{Size=1:4095}**

An unstructured list of the attributes that describe the physical characteristics of a person, place, or object.
Commas separate each attribute.
Example:

1 DSCR Hair Brown, Eyes Brown, Height 5 ft 8 in
2 DATE 23 JUL 1935

PLACE_LATITUDE:= **{Size=2:10}**

The value specifying the latitudinal coordinate of the place name. The latitude coordinate is the direction North or South from the equator in degrees and fraction of degrees carried out to give the desired accuracy. For example: 18 degrees, 9 minutes, and 3.4 seconds North would be formatted as N18.150944. Minutes and seconds are converted by dividing the minutes value by 60 and the seconds value by 3600 and adding the results together. This sum becomes the fractional part of the degree's value.

The shortest possible value is "N0", the longest possible value, with 6 decimals precision is "N89.123456".

PLACE_LONGITUDE:= **{Size=2:11}**

The value specifying the longitudinal coordinate of the place name. The longitude coordinate is Degrees and fraction of degrees east or west of the zero or base meridian coordinate. For example: 168 degrees, 9 minutes, and 3.4 seconds East would be formatted as E168.150944.

The shortest possible value is "E0", the longest possible value, with 6 decimals precision is "E179.123456".

Latitude and Longitude Standard

The FamilySearch GEDCOM specification provides a brief specification of how to record latitude and longitude in the <PLACE_LATITUDE> and <PLACE_LONGITUDE> definitions.

Standard formats for geographical coordinates are defined ISO 6709 *Standard representation of geographic point location by coordinates*.
This format always uses a full stop (.), never a comma (,), as a decimal stop.
Use of the characters N and S for North and South, and E and W for East and West as sign characters is defined in Annex H.

Several applications use the plus (+) and minus (-) sign as sign characters.
GEDCOM readers should accept both styles.

PLACE_NAME:= **{Size=1:120}**

[